



DESTINATION FILE

K'gari

The world's largest sand island — ancient dune lakes, rainforest growing in sand, and the purest wongari (dingo) population in eastern Australia.

COUNTRY

Butchulla Country, QLD

ACCESS

Barge from Hervey Bay area

PAX RANKING

#9 of all destinations

STATUS

●Open · 4WD & barge access only

01 Destination overview

LOCATION & SIZE

The world's largest sand island, roughly 122km long, off Queensland's Fraser Coast near Hervey Bay. World Heritage listed in 1992 for its sand-mass ecology — rainforest growing directly on dune sand, and over 100 perched freshwater lakes.

CHARACTER

Lake McKenzie (Boorangoora) and the other perched lakes, 75 Mile Beach run as a gazetted vehicle highway, and the purest remaining wongari (dingo) population in eastern Australia. There are no sealed roads — 4WD is essential everywhere on the island.

ACCESS

Vehicle and passenger barges run from River Heads (near Hervey Bay) to Wanggoolba Creek and Kingfisher Bay, and from Rainbow Beach (Inskip Point) to Hook Point in the south.

BEST SEASON

Winter (Jun-Aug) — cooler, drier, best for walking tracks. **Jul-Nov** — humpback whale migration season offshore. Avoid the wettest summer months for self-drive itineraries where possible.

GOVERNING BODIES

QPWS

Butchulla Aboriginal Corporation

Butchulla Native Title Aboriginal Corporation

K'gari World Heritage Advisory Committee

Fraser Coast Regional Council

LEGAL FRAMEWORKS

Nature Conservation Act 1992 (Qld)

EPBC Act 1999

World Heritage listing 1992

02 Butchulla Country

TRADITIONAL OWNERS

The Butchulla people have cared for K'gari for over 60,000 years; their connection to the island was recognised through Native Title determinations in 2014 and 2019.

FROM FRASER ISLAND TO K'GARI

The island's name was formally restored to K'gari in June 2023, with more than 19 hectares of land transferred to the Butchulla Aboriginal Corporation. In 2025, the World Heritage property's own name was changed at the 47th session of the World Heritage Committee, dropping the "(Fraser Island)" reference entirely — the old name commemorated Eliza Fraser, whose story directly led to the dispossession and massacre of Butchulla people.

CULTURAL SIGNIFICANCE

Wanggoolba Creek, at Central Station, is sacred to the Butchulla people — a quiet rainforest walk that's one of the island's most culturally significant sites.

PRIORITY RECOMMENDATION

Always use "K'gari" in client materials and conversation — never "Fraser Island." Where available, build in Butchulla-guided or Butchulla-interpreted experiences at Central Station.

03 Sustainability & current status

TOP PRESSURES

The K'gari World Heritage Advisory Committee has formally flagged climate change, over-visitation and biosecurity threats as the island's most urgent issues, in its most recent communique to the Queensland and Australian Governments.

RISING WONGARI (DINGO) CONFLICT

Food-related habituation is driving increasing dingo aggression on the island. QPWS has committed to a new K'gari Management Plan, due by the end of 2025, specifically to address this. Brief every client on dingo safety without exception.

VERIFIED ECO-CERTIFIED SUPPLIER

Kingfisher Bay Resort — an Orange Journeys accommodation supplier — holds Ecotourism Australia's Advanced Ecotourism certification. It's a genuine, verified point of difference worth recommending as the island's base.

BEFORE YOU SELL

Track and beach closures change seasonally — for example, a section near Sandy Cape is currently closed through January 2027. Always check the QPWS conditions report before every departure.

04 Biodiversity & environment

WHY IT MATTERS

K'gari's deep, nutrient-poor sand supports ecosystems found almost nowhere else — "perched" dune lakes held above the water table by compacted organic matter, and acid-tolerant frog species adapted to the resulting low-pH water.

KEY WILDLIFE

Wongari (dingo)

Flying foxes

Acid frogs

Humpback whale (seasonal)

350+ bird species

SPECIES TO KNOW

Wongari (dingo)

Protected — regarded as the purest remaining dingo strain in eastern Australia. Whelping season runs 1 June–30 September — extra caution required.

Humpback Whale

Seasonal migrant — passes offshore on migration, roughly July–November.

BE DINGO-SAFE

Never feed or approach a wongari. Keep children within arm's reach at all times. If approached, never run — stand tall and back away slowly. Store all food and rubbish securely, in vehicles or sealed containers, at every stop.

05 Getting there sustainably

BARGE CROSSING

Vehicle and passenger barges connect River Heads to Kingfisher Bay/Wanggoolba Creek, and Rainbow Beach to Hook Point. These trips carry a real per-vehicle footprint — consolidating group transport onto fewer vehicles where possible reduces it.

ON THE ISLAND

4WD is essential everywhere; there are no sealed roads or public transport. Guided tours put fewer vehicles on the island's fragile sand tracks than independent self-drive groups.

TIDE-TIMED BEACH DRIVING

75 Mile Beach is a gazetted road, but it's only safely driveable within set tide windows. Driving outside those windows risks vehicles and damages the beach ecosystem — always check tide tables before departure.

06 Accessibility

OVERALL

Limited. Sand terrain, no sealed paths, and most experiences require 4WD plus walking on sand or boardwalk.

LAKE MCKENZIE

The boardwalk to the main lookout point is more accessible; reaching the lake's edge itself involves walking on loose sand.

KINGFISHER BAY RESORT

The most accessible base on the island, with accessible rooms and boardwalk access — and Advanced Ecotourism certified, a strong recommendation for clients with mobility needs.

PLAN AHEAD

Confirm specific accessibility requirements with QPWS and the barge operator in advance — facilities outside the main resorts are limited.

